

Assuan, whilst Alexander settled Jews and Samaritans in Egypt as well as in the northern countries of Bactria; similarly the Seleucids, especially Antiochus the Great, settled Jewish garrisons in the northern provinces, as testified by Josephus.¹ This being the case, the whole situation assumes a different aspect.

The Samaritans became a political sect of Palestine, heavily garrisoned by Assyrian, and later by Persian, troops. During the period with which we are now dealing the country was for the time being under Persia, Cyrus, Darius, and Artaxerxes being the kings mentioned.² Moreover, Samaritan tradition says that these various nationalities were slowly drafted back into Assyria and Babylon after the re-settlement of the Israelites or that portion of them which had returned from the so-called First Exile under the leadership of the High Priest Serayah, the occasion for their return being described in the Book of Kings.

The reason for the conversion of these various heathen garrisons was, according to 2 Kings xvii. 25 ff., the plague of lions which infested the country. The colonists ascribed this calamity simply to their ignorance of the worship of the god of the land, but, considering that the best part of the population were still living there, the allegation is curious; nor does it explain how the return of the priest from Babylon could banish the lions. Surely more than one priest must have been left behind who could teach them the worship of the god of the land and thus save its inhabitants from the plague. The facts as recorded in the Book of Kings are evidently greatly reduced; they are a mere summary of the events, from which the writer never expected the consequences to flow which have subsequently been derived therefrom. In the Samaritan tradition the matter assumes a totally different aspect, and all the difficulties which this obscure passage presents are easily cleared away. They state that by having carried into exile the High Priest and the priests who ministered in the Sanctuary at Beth-el, i.e. Garizim, the service of God had come to a standstill. No more sacrifices were

¹ *Antiq.* xii. 3. 3, 4 (§ 147).

² This will explain the very curious fact that the garrison of Assuan appealed to both the High Priest of Jerusalem and to the Governor of Samaria, Sanballat, to come to its assistance when the town was taken and the temple destroyed by the Egyptians. Sanballat, however, was not the spiritual head; he was probably invested with the same power of governor as that afterwards conferred upon Nehemiah.